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Inventor(s)

DUGONI; Graham

METHODS AND SYSTEMS FOR CONTROLLING ACCESS TO AN ELECTRONIC DEVICE

Abstract

A system and apparatus for selectively limiting user control of a mobile electronic device are provided. In an embodiment, the apparatus may be a case sized to receive a mobile electronic device, the case having a locking means to at least partially secure an opening thereof. When engaged, the locking means may be physically impenetrable by the user of the mobile electronic device and may further be configured to engage and disengage in the presence of one or more pre-determined conditions. For example, the lock may engage when the case is detected within a certain geographical region or even during a specified time. It is contemplated that providing disclosed systems and apparatuses may reduce undesirable behavior at communal events by eliminating distractions posed by mobile electronic devices and preventing unauthorized recordings, which together may enhance overall engagement at and enjoyment of such events.

Inventors: DUGONI; Graham (Los Angeles, CA)

Applicant: Yondr, Inc. (Glendale, CA)

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Background/Summary

CROSS-REFERENCE TO RELATED APPLICATIONS [0001] Pursuant to 35 USC § 119, this continuation of U.S. patent application Ser. No. 18/951,790, filed on Nov. 19, 2024, which is a continuation of U.S. patent application Ser. No. 18/627,755, filed Apr. 5, 2024, now U.S. Pat. No. 12,156,030, which is continuation of U.S. patent application Ser. No. 18/517,675, filed Nov. 22, 2023, which is a divisional of U.S. patent application Ser. No. 16/813,437 filed on Mar. 9, 2020, now U.S. Pat. No. 12,133,074, which is a continuation of U.S. patent application Ser. No. 15/704,425, filed on Sep. 14, 2017, now U.S. Pat. No. 10,623,957, which is a continuation of U.S. patent application Ser. No. 14/692,530, filed on Apr. 21, 2015, now U.S. Pat. No. 9,819,788. The content of said applications are incorporated herein by reference in its entirety.

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TECHNICAL FIELD

[0003] The disclosed subject matter relates generally to systems and apparatuses for limiting functionality of personal electronic devices and, more particularly, to locking cases and other techniques that selectively limit a user's ability to access and control such electronic devices until predetermined conditions, such as geographic location and passage of time, are met.

BACKGROUND

[0004] Handheld and mobile electronic devices have become ubiquitous for conveniently enhancing wireless communication and connectivity. Still, the extent of their pervasive use has also proven to be unwelcome in certain settings.

[0005] In many instances, mobile electronic devices can distract users from appreciating their surroundings and company of others to a full extent. For example, many who bring their mobile electronic devices, such as cell phones, to social outings may find themselves foregoing live conversation to check their phones for text messages, missed calls, and other virtual communications. Additionally, as photo and video recording capabilities have improved, users have increasingly taken to using their mobile electronic devices to record performers, speakers, and even athletes at live events. This can be distracting to the performers and to others in the audience, detracting from overall enjoyment of the event. Indeed, this can even be harmful to the intellectual

property rights of performers whose copyrighted or otherwise valuable and legally protectable displays and performances are digitally recorded and distributed without authorization.

[0006] Attempts have been made to limit use of mobile electronic devices. For example, U.S. Pat. No. 7,181,229 to Singh et al. discloses a system that, in part, shuts off a cell phone and prevents a user from turning the cell phone on while it is within a restricted area, such as a car. This solution is deficient however, because it completely prevents users from being notified of any incoming calls or messages that may require the user's attention. The '229 patent further discloses a system that limits cell phone function when it is detected within an automobile. Aside from the geographically limited application of this invention, it is also deficient because it fails to blocks the screen to diminish possible temptation to use the device.

[0007] Other attempts to discourage use of mobile electronic devices at communal events and in certain venues have been largely ineffective. For example, providing signs and instructions to refrain from using mobile electronic devices in certain areas and/or during specified time periods are often ignored. Moreover, requiring people to leave mobile electronic devices at home, turn them off, or to physically turn them over to venue staff for the duration of an event is often met with resistance. This may be because users prefer not to be separated from their valuable personal property, fearing theft of their devices and electronically stored information, and even the risk of missing important messages or other notifications.

[0008] Thus, although various proposals have been made to solve the problem, none of those in existence combine the characteristics of the present invention. Therefore, there remains a need for a system and apparatus that selectively limits access to and/or disables functions of a mobile electronic device.

SUMMARY

[0009] The present disclosure is directed to techniques for limiting access to and control of personal mobile electronic devices within certain geographic locations or even during specified periods of time.

[0010] For purposes of summarizing, certain aspects, advantages, and novel features have been described. It is to be understood that not all such advantages may be achieved in accordance with any one particular embodiment. Thus, the disclosed subject matter may be embodied or carried out in a manner that achieves or optimizes one advantage or group of advantages without achieving all advantages as may be taught or suggested.

[0011] In one embodiment, among others, the apparatus is a case sized to accommodate a mobile electronic device. More particularly, the case may comprise a front and a rear panel secured together along longitudinally opposed side edges and laterally opposed lower edges. Configured in this manner, the front and rear panels and sealed edges may define an opening to receive the mobile electronic device.

[0012] The case may additionally comprise a locking means for at least partially securing the opening. The locking means may comprise opposing plates disposed on or within the front and rear panels of the case. More particularly, opposing plates respectively having securably mateable female and a male members are contemplated. It is additionally contemplated that the locking means may first render the electronic device inaccessible to the user, or in other words possessor, of the device and second be non-disengageable by the user of the mobile electronic device until predetermined condition is met. In other words, when engaged, the locking means may be physically impenetrable by the user of the mobile electronic device and may further be configured to disengage to provide the user with access to his or her mobile electronic device only under certain circumstances.

[0013] For example, predetermined condition may relate to geographic location or timing. Indeed, in one embodiment, the case may be used to render a mobile electronic device inaccessible during a communal event such as a show, demonstration, display, or athletic competition within a concert hall, center, arena, or similar venue. In such scenarios, the locking means may only become

disengageable if a user leaves the venue. Alternatively, the locking means may only become disengageable at such a time as the communal event is completed. As yet another alternative, the locking means may become disengageable when a user locates venue staff who are equipped to physically disengage the locking means on their behalf.

[0014] In an embodiment, the locking means may be remotely engageable and disengageable. The locking means may be equipped with electronic receivers such as a radio frequency identification (RFID) configured to instruct the locking means to alternatively engage and disengage when it receives a signal from a proximity transmitter indicating that the case has respectively entered and exited defined geographical region. Thus, for example, the locking means may receive instructions to lock the device when it is located within an audience seating area of a venue or concert hall. Then, the locking device may receive instructions to unlock the device when it is located outside of the audience area of a venue or concert hall.

[0015] In still another embodiment, the locking device may be equipped with a microprocessor configured to receive Bluetooth™ or other wireless data signals from a beacon or transmitter within a defined perimeter. Thus, for example, receipt of a wireless data signal may cause the locking means on the case to engage so that it restricts access to the mobile electronic device housed within the case. In other examples, the absence of a wireless data signal may cause the locking device to engage.

[0016] It is contemplated that providing disclosed systems and apparatuses according to the disclosure and claims provided below may reduce undesirable behavior at communal events by eliminating distractions posed by mobile electronic devices and preventing unauthorized recordings, which together may enhance overall engagement at and enjoyment of such events.

[0017] Thus, it is an object of the invention to eliminate distractions caused by use of mobile electronic devices at communal events.

[0018] It is another object of the invention to prevent users from controlling their mobile electronic devices within certain locations.

[0019] It is yet another object of the invention to prevent users from controlling their mobile electronic devices during certain periods of time.

[0020] It is still another object of the invention to avoid possible infringement of intellectual property rights caused by unauthorized use of recording features available on many mobile electronic devices.

[0021] It is another object of the invention to protect personal privacy of those surrounding users of mobile electronic devices at communal events by preventing such users from photographing and recording them, and even further preventing such users from sharing any impermissibly captured photos and recordings.

[0022] One or more of the above-disclosed embodiments, in addition to certain alternatives, are provided in further detail below with reference to the attached figures. The disclosed subject matter is not, however, limited to any particular embodiment disclosed.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

[0023] FIG. 1 is a perspective view of an embodiment of the case for selectively limiting user control of an electronic device.

[0024] FIG. 2 is an alternate perspective view of an embodiment of the case for selectively limiting user control of an electronic device.

[0025] FIG. 3 is a skeletal view of an embodiment of the case for selectively limiting user control of an electronic device.

[0026] FIG. 4 illustrates an embodiment of means for locking the embodiment of the case for

selectively limiting user control of an electronic device in FIGS. 1-3.

[0027] FIGS. 5 and 6 show an embodiment of means for unlocking an embodiment of the case for selectively limiting user control of an electronic device.

[0028] FIG. 7 is a schematic representation of an embodiment of the system for selectively limiting user control of an electronic device.

[0029] FIG. 8 illustrates an exemplary embodiment of a mobile electronic device practicing an embodiment of the system for selectively limiting user control of the electronic device.

[0030] The disclosed embodiments may be better understood by referring to the figures in the attached drawings, as provided below. The attached figures are provided as non-limiting examples for providing an enabling description of the system and apparatus claimed. Attention is called to the fact, however, that the appended drawings illustrate only typical embodiments of this invention and are therefore not to be considered as limiting of its scope. One skilled in the art will understand that the invention may be practiced without some of the details included in order to provide a thorough enabling description of such embodiments.

[0031] Well-known structures and functions have not been shown or described in detail to avoid unnecessarily obscuring the description of the embodiments.

[0032] One embodiment of the invention is implemented as a program product for use with a computer system. The program(s) of the program product defines functions of the embodiments (including the methods described herein) and can be contained on a variety of computer-readable storage media. Illustrative computer-readable storage media include, but are not limited to: (i) non-writable storage media (e.g., read-only memory devices within a computer such as CD-ROM disks readable by a CD-ROM drive) on which information is permanently stored; (ii) writable storage media (e.g., floppy disks within a diskette drive or hard-disk drive) on which alterable information is stored. Such computer-readable storage media, when carrying computer-readable instructions that direct the functions of the present invention, are embodiments of the present invention. Other media include communications media through which information is conveyed to a computer, such as through a computer or telephone network, including wireless communications networks. The latter embodiment specifically includes transmitting information to/from the Internet and other networks. Such communications media, when carrying computer-readable instructions that direct the functions of the present invention, are embodiments of the present invention. Broadly, computer-readable storage media and communications media may be referred to herein as computer-readable media.

[0033] In general, the routines executed to implement the embodiments of the invention, may be part of an operating system or a specific application, component, program, module, object, or sequence of instructions. The computer program of the present invention typically is comprised of a multitude of instructions that will be translated by the native computer into a machine-readable format and hence executable instructions. Also, programs are comprised of variables and data structures that either reside locally to the program or are found in memory or on storage devices. In addition, various programs described hereinafter may be identified based upon the application for which they are implemented in a specific embodiment of the invention. However, it should be appreciated that any particular program nomenclature that follows is used merely for convenience, and thus the invention should not be limited to use solely in any specific application identified and/or implied by such nomenclature.

[0034] For simplicity and clarity of illustration, the drawing figures illustrate the general manner of construction, and descriptions and details of well-known features and techniques may be omitted to avoid unnecessarily obscuring the invention. Additionally, elements in the drawing figures are not necessarily drawn to scale. For example, the dimensions of some of the elements in the figures may be exaggerated relative to other elements to help improve understanding of embodiments of the present invention. The same reference numerals in different figures denote the same elements.

[0035] The terms “first,” “second,” “third,” “fourth,” and the like in the description and in the

claims, if any, are used for distinguishing between similar elements and not necessarily for describing a particular sequential or chronological order. It is to be understood that the terms so used are interchangeable under appropriate circumstances such that the embodiments described herein are, for example, capable of operation in sequences other than those illustrated or otherwise described herein. Furthermore, the terms “include,” and “have,” and any variations thereof, are intended to cover a non-exclusive inclusion, such that a process, method, system, article, device, or apparatus that comprises a list of elements is not necessarily limited to those elements, but may include other elements not expressly listed or inherent to such process, method, system, article, device, or apparatus.

[0036] The terms “couple,” “coupled,” “couples,” “coupling,” and the like should be broadly understood and refer to connecting two or more elements or signals, electrically, mechanically or otherwise. Two or more electrical elements may be electrically coupled, but not mechanically or otherwise coupled; two or more mechanical elements may be mechanically coupled, but not electrically or otherwise coupled; two or more electrical elements may be mechanically coupled, but not electrically or otherwise coupled. Coupling (whether mechanical, electrical, or otherwise) may be for any length of time, e.g., permanent or semi-permanent or only for an instant.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

[0037] Having summarized various aspects of the present disclosure, reference will now be made in detail to that which is illustrated in the drawings. While the disclosure will be described in connection with these drawings, there is no intent to limit it to the embodiment or embodiments disclosed herein. Rather, the intent is to cover all alternatives, modifications and equivalents included within the spirit and scope of the disclosure as defined by the appended claims.

[0038] With reference to FIGS. **1-4** the apparatus for selectively limiting user control of an electronic device may be embodied as a case **100** sized to accommodate a mobile electronic device **102**. More particularly, the case may comprise a front **104** and a rear panel **106** secured together along longitudinally opposed side edges **108** and laterally opposed lower edges **110**. The lower edges **110** may be secured by permanently stitching or gluing together, while the side edges **108** may be stitched or glued upward from the lower toward an opening **112** that is defined by the front and rear panels **104, 106** and permanently secured edges **108, 110** and further sized to receive the mobile electronic device **102**.

[0039] As illustrated, one embodiment of the apparatus may be a soft, flexible case. It may comprise various rugged materials such as neoprene, lycra, silicone rubber, spandex, vinyl, canvas, and any other material or combinations of materials sufficient to temporarily house a mobile electronic device. Additionally, various other configurations are contemplated for the shape of the apparatus as well. For example, the invention may comprise a rigid shell or box having a securable opening to receive a mobile electronic device. As such, one skilled in the art will recognize that the illustrated figures are offered by way of example and ease of understanding only, not of limitation.

[0040] The apparatus for selectively limiting user control of an electronic device further comprises a locking means **114** for at least partially securing the opening **112** so the mobile electronic device **102** is may be rendered inaccessible to and further uncontrollable by the user of the device although it may still remain in his possession.

[0041] In one embodiment, the locking means **114** comprises opposing plates disposed on or within the front and rear panels **106, 108** of the case **100**, and to effect locking, each opposing plate has one of a securably mateable female **114a** and male **114b** member. Other locking means are, of course, contemplated. For example, magnetic plates, selectively releasable mesh, lockable zippers, and other means for at least partially securing the opening **112** may be sufficient to practice the invention. In this manner, the locking means **114** may first render the electronic device **102** inaccessible to the user by at least partially securing the opening **112** of the device, and second be non-disengageable by the user of the mobile electronic device until a predetermined condition is met.

[0042] One or more embodiments of the case **100** may be configured to selectively limit access to a mobile electronic device **102** in response to various predetermined conditions. In one embodiment, the case may be outfitted with locking means **114** comprising a manual, key-operated latch wherein means for unlocking comprise a corresponding key. In such an embodiment, the case **100** may be manually locked or unlocked by venue staff or other members in possession of such a key. Thus, the system for selectively limiting user control of an electronic device may involve a predetermined condition requiring the user of the electronic device **102** to locate venue staff or other members in possession of the key to manually unlock the case **100** on user's behalf.

[0043] With reference to FIGS. **5** and **6**, the system **500** for selectively limiting user control of an electronic device may comprise a locking means **114** having electronic receivers, such as a radio frequency identification (RFID) tag and means for unlocking the case **100** comprising an electronic article surveillance (EAS) detacher **502** for separating the mating portions of the locking means **114**. The EAS detacher **502** may be, for example, any of those known in the to contain strong magnets that interrupt electromagnetic fields such as those in the range of radio frequencies. Thus, in one embodiment represented by FIG. **5**, the at least partially secured locking means **114** may be touched to the EAS detacher **502** so that any electromagnetic fields enabling the locking means **114** to remain secured are interrupted. This, in turn, may allow the locking means **114** to become unsecured and further exposes the mobile electronic device **102** within the case as in FIG. **6**. In such an embodiment, it is contemplated that the predetermined condition involves locating an EAS detacher. In the event that the system and apparatus for selectively limiting user control of an electronic device is employed to reduce distractions at a communal event, such means for unlocking the case may be placed out side of any audience viewing area or even at venue exit ways.

[0044] The means for unlocking the case may also operate remotely to cause the case to automatically lock and unlock. For example, in one embodiment, the locking means may automatically lock and unlock when the case is determined to be, respectively, within and outside of a defined geographical region. For example, with reference to FIG. **7**, another embodiment of the system may comprise locking means **114** having electronic receivers such as the aforementioned RFID tag disposed therein and further configured to instruct the locking means to alternatively engage and disengage when it receives a signal from a proximity transmitter **702**. Thus, for example, the locking means may receive instructions to lock the device when it is located in **100a** the geographical region **704** within reach of the transmitter **702**. Then, the locking means **114** may receive instructions to unlock the device when it is located outside **100b** of the geographical region **704** within reach of the transmitter **702**. In such an embodiment, it is contemplated that the predetermined condition requires a user to exit a geographical region to regain access and control of his or her mobile electronic device. As a more particularized example, a transmitter signal may be configured to cover the geographical region of an audience seating area at a venue hosting a communal event. When within the audience seating area, the case **100a** may remain secured so that a user is unable to access or control the mobile electronic device contained therein. However, when the case **100b** travels outside of the audience seating area, such as to a foyer, lobby, or restroom, the locking means **114** may become unsecured to provide access to the mobile electronic device. It should be understood that such a limitation is offered by way of example only. The transmitter signal may be configured to cover any desirable area, and indeed a plurality of transmitters **702** may even be employed to enlarge or otherwise define the geographical region affecting access and control of the mobile electronic device.

[0045] In still another embodiment, the locking device may be equipped with a microprocessor configured to receive Bluetooth™ or other wireless data signals from a beacon or transmitter within a defined perimeter. Thus, for example, receipt of a wireless data signal may cause the locking means on the case to engage so that it restricts access to the mobile electronic device housed within the case. In other examples, the absence of a wireless data signal may cause the

locking device to engage.

[0046] In addition to geographical proximity to electromagnetic and other wireless data signals, the predetermined condition may also or alternatively relate to the passage of time. For example, the locking means may automatically become unsecured at the time that a communal event is scheduled to end or even during intermissions. Thus a transmitter may produce a signal causing the locking means to remain secured for a period of time. When the period of time elapses, the transmitter may stop producing the signal so that the locking means becomes unsecured. Of course, various other predetermined conditions and means for unlocking may signal or prompt the release of the locking means, and the foregoing are offered only for the purpose of enabling the system and apparatus. In any event, when engaged, the locking means may be physically impenetrable by the user of the mobile electronic device and may further be configured to automatically or manually disengage to provide the user with access to his or her mobile electronic device only under certain circumstances.

[0047] In still another embodiment, the mobile electronic device **102** itself includes an embodiment of the system for selectively limiting user control of an electronic device. The system can be implemented in numerous ways such as, for example and without limitation, those discussed above, and even as an application executed on the mobile electronic device **102**. In operation, an embodiment of the system receives information from integrated positioning technology, such as Global Position Systems (GPS) to selectively limit a user's ability to control his or her mobile electronic device. Of course, one skilled in the art will recognize that various methods of determining the location of a mobile electronic device can be used.

[0048] In a further embodiment, a geofence may be created around a venue for a communal event, or other location where it may be desirable to limit use of a mobile electronic device, so that the system automatically disables certain functional capabilities of the mobile electronic device **102** any time the device comes within a predetermined distance of the venue or other location. For example, a mobile electronic device within the geofence may be rendered incapable of sending or receiving voice and/or text messages. As another example, a mobile electronic device within the geofence may be incapable of running applications or other programs operative to capture audio and/or visual recordings. As yet another example, a mobile electronic device within the geofence may be rendered incapable of receiving or transmitting data through the Internet and other networks.

[0049] FIG. **8** illustrates an exemplary embodiment of a mobile electronic device **102** that may be compatible with one or more embodiments of the disclosed system and apparatus. The mobile electronic device **102** may be a cell phone, smart phone, or tablet computer but may also be embodied in any one of a wide variety of wired and/or wireless computing devices. As shown in FIG. **8**, mobile electronic device **102** includes a processing device (processor) **802**, input/output interfaces **804**, a display **806**, a touchscreen interface **808**, a network interface **810**, memory **812**, and operating system **814**, a mass storage **816** and a GPS **818**, with each communicating across a local data bus **820**. Additionally, mobile electronic device **102** incorporates a system for selectively limiting user control of an electronic device **102**, which may optionally be configured to include programming instructions to selectively disable any of the aforementioned features of the mobile electronic device **102**. For example, in one embodiment, the system for selectively limiting user control of an electronic device **102** may communicate instructions to disable input/output interfaces **804**.

[0050] The processing device **802** may include any custom made or commercially available processor, a central processing unit (CPU) or an auxiliary processor among several processors associated with the mobile electronic device **102**, a semiconductor based microprocessor (in the form of a microchip), a macroprocessor, one or more application specific integrated circuits (ASICs), a plurality of suitably configured digital logic gates, and other electrical configurations comprising discrete elements both individually and in various combinations to coordinate the

overall operation of the system.

[0051] The memory **812** can include any one of a combination of volatile memory elements (e.g., random-access memory (RAM, such as DRAM, and SRAM, etc.)) and nonvolatile memory elements. The memory typically comprises native operating system **814**, one or more native applications, emulation systems, or emulated applications for any of a variety of operating systems and/or emulated hardware platforms, emulated operating systems, etc. For example, the applications may include application specific software which may comprise some or all the components of the mobile electronic device **102**. In accordance with such embodiments, the components are stored in memory and executed by the processing device. Note that although depicted separately in FIG. **8**, the system selectively limiting user control of an electronic device **102** may be resident in memory such as memory **812**.

[0052] Touchscreen interface **808** may be configured to detect contact within the display area of the display **806** and provides such functionality as on-screen buttons, menus, keyboards, etc. that allows users to navigate user interfaces by touch. Some embodiment of the mobile electronic device **102** will even comprise GPS **818** or other means to determine the location of the mobile electronic device **102**.

[0053] [One of ordinary skill in the art will appreciate that the memory **814** can, and typically will, comprise other components that have been omitted for purposes of brevity. Note that in the context of this disclosure, a non-transitory computer-readable medium stores one or more programs for use by or in connection with an instruction execution system, apparatus, or device. With further reference to FIG. **8**, network interface device **810** comprises various components used to transmit and/or receive data over a networked environment. When such components are embodied as an application, such as an application for executing and embodiment of the system for selectively limiting user control of the electronic device, the one or more components may be stored on a non-transitory computer-readable medium and executed by the processing device.

[0054] It should be emphasized that the above-described embodiments are merely examples of possible implementations. Many variations and modifications may be made to the above-described embodiments without departing from the principles of the present disclosure. All such modifications and variations are intended to be included herein within the scope of this disclosure and protected by the following claims.

[0055] Moreover, embodiments and limitations disclosed herein are not dedicated to the public under the doctrine of dedication if the embodiments and/or limitations: (1) are not expressly claimed in the claims; and (2) are or are potentially equivalents of express elements and/or limitations in the claims under the doctrine of equivalents.

CONCLUSIONS, RAMIFICATIONS, AND SCOPE

[0056] While certain embodiments of the invention have been illustrated and described, various modifications are contemplated and can be made without departing from the spirit and scope of the invention. For example, communal events are discussed as venues for implementation of the invention, however it is contemplated that the system and apparatus disclosed may be applied to small scale and even private venues such as for example, a private home, a restaurant, members-only club, and even automobile or other vehicle. Accordingly, it is intended that the invention not be limited, except as by the appended claim(s).

[0057] The teachings disclosed herein may be applied to other systems and apparatuses, and may not necessarily be limited to any described herein. The elements and acts of the various embodiments described above can be combined to provide further embodiments. All of the above patents and applications and other references, including any that may be listed in accompanying filing papers, are incorporated herein by reference. Aspects of the invention can be modified, if necessary, to employ the systems, functions and concepts of the various references described above to provide yet further embodiments of the invention.

[0058] Particular terminology used when describing certain features or aspects of the invention

should not be taken to imply that the terminology is being refined herein to be restricted to any specific characteristics, features, or aspects of the system and apparatus for selectively limiting user control of an electronic device with which that terminology is associated. In general, the terms used in the following claims should not be constructed to limit the system and apparatus for selectively limiting user control of an electronic device to the specific embodiments disclosed in the specification unless the above description section explicitly define such terms. Accordingly, the actual scope encompasses not only the disclosed embodiments, but also all equivalent ways of practicing or implementing the disclosed system and apparatus. The above description of embodiments of the system and apparatus for selectively limiting user control of an electronic device is not intended to be exhaustive or limited to the precise form disclosed above or to a particular field of usage.

[0059] While specific embodiments of, and examples for, the method, system, and apparatus are described above for illustrative purposes, various equivalent modifications are possible for which those skilled in the relevant art will recognize.

[0060] While certain aspects of the method and system disclosed are presented below in particular claim forms, various aspects of the system and apparatus are contemplated in any number of claim forms. Thus, the inventor reserves the right to add additional claims after filing the application to pursue such additional claim forms for other aspects of the system and apparatus for selectively limiting user control of an electronic device.

Claims

1. A system, comprising: a flexible case, the case comprising: a front panel having a lower edge and sides that are longer than the lower edge; a rear panel having a lower edge stitched to the front panel's lower edge and sides that are approximately the same length as the front panel's sides, wherein the front and rear panels' respective sides are closed thereby forming an opening to a cavity opposite the lower edges, the cavity sized to receive a user's mobile electronic device, wherein the mobile electronic device is a cell phone or smart phone; and a lock, comprising: a first locking member outside of the cavity and connected to the front panel; a second locking member outside of the cavity and connected to the rear panel, the second locking member configured to engage the first locking member; and a closure configured to lock the first and second locking members together, the lock configured to secure the case in a closed position such that it limits the user's access to their mobile electronic device; and a separate detachable comprising: a holder; and a magnet within the holder configured to unlock the closure such that when the closure is brought close to or in contact with the detachable, the lock unlocks and the user may access their mobile electronic device.
2. The system of claim 1, wherein the front panel is configured to fold away from the rear panel such that the cavity opens to access the user's mobile electronic device.
3. The system of claim 1, the first locking member further comprising a first plate stitched within the front panel, and the second locking member further comprising a second plate stitched within the rear panel.
4. The system of claim 1, the closure further comprising a male member and a female member.
5. The system of claim 4, wherein the first locking member, second locking member, and male and female members form a key-operated latch, and wherein the detachable serves as a corresponding key.
6. The system of claim 4, the closure further comprising a pin insertable in a corresponding hole to secure the lock in a closed position.
7. The system of claim 1, wherein the front panel can fold together with the rear panel in a closed configuration.
8. The system of claim 1, wherein the lock is configured to automatically lock or unlock.

9. The system of claim 1, the holder comprising a surface configured so that the magnet unlocks the lock when at least a portion of the lock touches the surface.

10. A method for reducing distraction from a user's mobile electronic device at a communal event, comprising: placing a user's mobile electronic device, wherein the mobile electronic device is a cell phone or a smart phone, within a cavity of a flexible case, the flexible case comprising: first and second flexible panels, each having a bottom edge and sides that are longer than the bottom edges, wherein the first and second panels' respective sides and bottom edges form the cavity, the cavity sized to receive the mobile electronic device, and a lock that can be disengaged with a magnetic detacher; selectively limiting the user's access to the user's mobile electronic device during a communal event by locking the user's mobile electronic device within the flexible case with the lock, by: coupling a first locking member connected to the first panel with a second locking member connected to the second panel; and securing the lock using a closure configured to lock the first and second locking members together; and keeping the lock closed for at least part of the communal event, thereby reducing distraction from the user's mobile electronic device at the event.

11. The method of claim 10, further comprising: allowing the user to retain possession of their mobile electronic device while the flexible case is locked, rendering the mobile electronic device inaccessible to and further uncontrollable by the user.

12. The method of claim 11, further comprising: restoring the user's control over the user's mobile electronic device by providing a separate detacher, the detacher comprising: a holder; and a magnet within the holder; wherein the magnet is configured to interrupt the closure such that when the closure touches the detacher the lock unlocks and the user may access their mobile electronic device.

13. The method of claim 11, further comprising: unlocking the lock by a venue staff member in possession of a key, the unlocking comprising: touching a portion of the lock on the key, the key comprising: a magnet configured to interrupt the closure such that when the closure touches the key the lock unlocks and the user may access their mobile electronic device.

14. The method of claim 10, wherein the locking the user's mobile electronic device within the flexible case further comprises latching the lock together.

15. The method of claim 10, further comprising: providing a detacher or key to unlock the lock at an exit to a venue such that the selective limiting user control their mobile electronic device reduces distractions at the communal event.

16. The method of claim 10, further comprising: providing a detacher or key to unlock the magnetic lock at an exit to a venue such that the selective limiting user control of their mobile electronic device protects personal privacy of those surrounding the users of mobile electronic devices at the communal event.

17. The method of claim 12, further comprising: enhancing overall engagement by limiting the mobile electronic device user's access to the detacher during at least part of the communal event by waiting to restore the user's control over the user's mobile electronic device until a predetermined condition is met.

18. A flexible case for a cell phone, comprising: a cavity to receive a cell phone; and a lock, comprising: a closure to lock the flexible case in a closed position and prevent the user from controlling their cell phone within certain locations, wherein the lock is configured to unlock when the closure locking mechanism is interrupted by a detacher.

19. The case of claim 18, the lock further comprising a latch.

20. The case of claim 18, wherein the cavity is formed from first and second flexible panels that are approximately symmetrical and have approximately equal lengths, and wherein the material forming the first and second flexible panels is at least partially stitched together.

21. The case of claim 18, the lock further comprising: a first plate stitched within the first panel, the first panel forming a side of the case; and a second plate stitched within the second panel, the second panel forming a second side of the case, the panels being formed from a soft, flexible

material.

22. The case of claim 21, the lock further comprising: a male member; and a female member.

23. The case of claim 22, each of the panels comprising neoprene, lycra, silicone rubber, spandex, vinyl, or canvas.

24. The case of claim 23, the male member comprising a pin and the female member comprising a corresponding hole with a locking mechanism to secure the lock closed prior to unlocking with a detacher.

25. The case of claim 23, wherein the male member comprises a latch.

26. The case of claim 18, wherein the cavity is formed from a first panel and a second panel, wherein the first panel is configured to fold over the second panel, the lock further comprising a latch.

27. The case of claim 18, wherein the lock is configured to automatically lock or unlock.

28. The case of claim 18, wherein the lock is positioned above the middle of the length of the case, in the direction of the opening to the cavity, and wherein portions of the lock are visible from opposing external sides of the case on each panel when the case is in an open position.

29. The case of claim 26, the case further comprising magnetic plates that at least partially secure the opening.

30. A method for reducing the distraction caused by a mobile electronic device at a venue, comprising: identifying a venue where mobile electronic devices are likely to cause distraction during a communal event; providing a flexible case to a user of a mobile electronic device, wherein the mobile electronic device is a cell phone or a smart phone, the case comprising: a front panel having a lower edge and sides that are longer than the lower edge; a rear panel having a lower edge stitched to the front panel's lower edge and sides that are approximately the same length as the front panel's sides, wherein the front and rear panels' respective sides are closed thereby forming an opening to a cavity opposite the lower edges, wherein the cavity is sized to receive the mobile electronic device; and a lock, comprising: a first locking member outside of the cavity and connected to the front panel; a second locking member outside of the cavity and connected to the rear panel, the second locking member configured to engage the first locking member; and a closure configured to lock the first and second locking members together, wherein the lock is configured to secure the case in a closed position and is further configured to prevent a user from controlling their electronic device; and limiting the user's control over the user's mobile electronic device at the venue by causing the case to be locked with the user's mobile electronic device within the case, thereby reducing the distraction caused by the user's mobile electronic device at the communal event.
